



KARNATAKA MEDICAL ADMISSIONS · 2026-27

The Complete KEA NEET UG Counselling Handbook 2026

Everything You Need to Navigate Karnataka
Medical Admissions with Confidence

Eligibility & Seat Types

Step-by-Step Registration

Document Checklist

Choice Filling Strategy

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How to Use This Handbook

This handbook is designed to be read once in full before your counselling window opens, then kept nearby as a reference during registration, document verification, and choice filling. It explains the process end-to-end so that a date change or a portal update never catches you off guard.

Status as of this publication — July 28, 2026

NEET UG 2026 was cancelled following alleged paper-leak concerns and a re-examination was conducted on **June 21, 2026**.

The Karnataka Examinations Authority (KEA) opened online counselling registration on its portal (cetonline.karnataka.gov.in) with an initial window and later **extended the registration deadline to July 30, 2026**, ahead of NEET results being fully processed into the counselling system.

As of publication, KEA had **not yet released the round-wise counselling calendar** (document verification, choice filling, mock allotment, and seat allotment dates) for 2026, and roll-number linking with results was still pending on the portal.

This handbook explains the process, eligibility, and documentation that stay consistent every year. Wherever an exact date, cutoff, or fee figure is not yet officially published, this is stated plainly instead of being estimated. Always cross-check the live schedule at cetonline.karnataka.gov.in before acting on any date.

Disclaimer

This handbook is an educational reference prepared to help students and parents understand the Karnataka NEET UG counselling process. It is **not** an official KEA publication. Admissions are governed exclusively by official KEA notifications, and in case of any discrepancy between this handbook and an official KEA notification, the **latest official KEA notification prevails**. Readers should always verify current updates on the official KEA website (cetonline.karnataka.gov.in) before registering, paying any fee, or reporting to a college.

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01 Understanding KEA Counselling

The Karnataka Examinations Authority (KEA) is the state body responsible for conducting centralised counselling for MBBS, BDS, and AYUSH admissions under the Karnataka state quota. If you've qualified NEET-UG, KEA counselling is the process that stands between your rank and an actual seat in a medical college.

It helps to understand upfront that Karnataka medical admission is split across two separate counselling authorities, and mixing them up is one of the most common sources of confusion for first-time candidates and parents alike.

Two Counselling Bodies, One Goal



MCC — All India Quota (15%)

Conducted by the Medical Counselling Committee for 15% of government college seats, open to candidates across India. Deemed university seats are also filled through MCC, not KEA.



KEA — State Quota (85% + Private)

Conducted by KEA for the remaining 85% government quota seats, plus private, management, minority, and NRI quota seats across Karnataka's medical colleges.

This handbook focuses entirely on the **KEA-conducted process**. If you're also registering for MCC counselling, treat the two as parallel, independent tracks — a seat allotted in one does not automatically affect your status in the other, but you are usually expected to follow each authority's own rules on reporting and seat retention.

WHY THIS DISTINCTION MATTERS



Every year, some candidates assume that registering with MCC covers their Karnataka state quota seat, or vice versa. It does not. You must register separately with KEA for state quota, private, and management seats.

Who Runs the Show

KEA conducts counselling under the overall regulatory framework of the National Medical Commission (NMC), and colleges are affiliated to Rajiv Gandhi University of Health Sciences (RGUHS) unless they are deemed universities. Every seat allotted through KEA is ultimately subject to approval by these bodies.

"Counselling is not a single event — it is a sequence of verification checkpoints. Missing one checkpoint, even by a few hours, can remove you from that round entirely."

Keep this in mind as you go through the rest of this handbook: KEA counselling rewards preparation and punctuality far more than it rewards a marginally better NEET rank. A well-prepared candidate with a modest rank routinely secures a better outcome than an unprepared candidate with a stronger one.

Eligibility & Types of Seats

Basic Eligibility

- Qualified NEET-UG 2026 with the minimum qualifying percentile applicable to your category
- Passed 10+2 / 2nd PUC (or equivalent) with Physics, Chemistry, Biology/Biotechnology, and English as compulsory subjects, with the minimum aggregate marks specified for your category
- Meet the age and nationality criteria prescribed for the counselling year

PENDING OFFICIAL RELEASE



At the time of publication, KEA has not yet released the exact 2026 qualifying percentile and category-wise minimum marks. Do not rely on any date circulating on coaching or aggregator websites — confirm only from the official KEA notification once published.

Karnataka Domicile — Why It Matters

State quota seats (85% of government college seats, plus most private and minority seats) are reserved for candidates who meet Karnataka's domicile requirements. Broadly, this means you or your parent must have studied in Karnataka for the required number of consecutive years, or otherwise meet KEA's residency, Kannada/Tulu/Kodava linguistic, or parent-domicile clauses.

KEA RULE



Domicile clauses are detailed and have specific documentary requirements for each category. Don't assume you qualify based on general residence in Karnataka — check your specific clause against the current KEA information bulletin before you register.

Non-domicile candidates are not excluded from Karnataka altogether — they remain eligible for private, management quota, and NRI quota seats, which do not carry the same domicile restriction.

Types of Seats Under KEA Counselling

SEAT TYPE	WHO IT'S FOR	NOTES
Government Quota	Karnataka-domicile candidates	Lowest fees; most competitive cutoffs
Private Quota (State Counselling)	Karnataka-domicile candidates	Filled through KEA at private college fee levels
Management Quota	Domicile and non-domicile candidates	Fee levels are typically the highest of all categories
NRI Quota	NRI, OCI, PIO candidates and their wards	Fees usually payable in foreign currency; separate document set required
Minority Quota	Candidates meeting the religious/linguistic minority criteria of the specific institution	Applicable only at minority-status colleges

Note: Deemed university seats are filled entirely through MCC counselling, not KEA, even though the colleges may be located in Karnataka.

Reservation Categories

Seats within each quota are further distributed across reservation categories — SC, ST, OBC (Category-1, 2A, 2B, 3A, 3B), EWS, and PwD — as prescribed under Karnataka's reservation policy. Candidates claiming a reservation category must hold a valid category certificate issued by a competent Karnataka authority; certificates issued by other states are generally not accepted for state quota reservation.

03 THE BIG PICTURE

The Complete Counselling Workflow

Every KEA counselling round follows the same underlying sequence, whether it's Round 1 or the Stray Vacancy round. Once you understand this flow, every KEA notification you read afterward will simply be slotting dates into a structure you already recognise.

1 Online Registration

Register on cetonline.karnataka.gov.in with NEET roll number, personal details, and category information. Upload documents in the specified format and pay the registration fee.

2 Document Verification

Attend verification (online or at a designated centre, as notified) with originals and photocopies. Only verified candidates proceed to the next stage.

3 Merit List & Rank Publication

KEA publishes the state merit list based on NEET rank, category, and verified eligibility.

4 Option Entry / Choice Filling

Enter your college and course preferences in strict order of priority. This is the single most consequential step in the entire process.

5 Mock Allotment

A trial allotment is published based on choices entered so far, letting you gauge where you stand before the choices lock.

6 Option Modification

A short window to revise your choice order based on the mock allotment result, before choices lock permanently for the round.

7 Seat Allotment Result

The final round result is published. If allotted, you must act within the stipulated window to retain the seat.

8 Fee Payment & Reporting

Pay the seat acceptance fee and report to the allotted institution with original documents within the deadline.

9 Subsequent Rounds

Unfilled and vacated seats move into Round 2, Mop-Up, and Stray Vacancy rounds, each with its own choice filling and allotment cycle.

THIS REPEATS EVERY ROUND



Steps 4 through 8 repeat for Round 2, Mop-Up, and Stray Vacancy. Each round has its own fresh option entry — seats and cutoffs shift as candidates from earlier rounds are removed from contention.

04 PREPARATION Documents Required

Document issues are the single biggest reason candidates lose time — or lose a round entirely — during KEA counselling. Start collecting these well before your verification slot, not the night before.

 Class 10 marksheet / certificate (date of birth proof)	 Class 12 / 2nd PUC marksheet
 Class 12 / 2nd PUC passing certificate	 NEET-UG 2026 admit card
 NEET-UG 2026 scorecard / rank card	 NEET-UG 2026 application confirmation page
 KEA counselling registration slip / application form	 Seat allotment letter (once allotted)
 Valid government photo ID (Aadhaar / PAN / Passport / Voter ID)	 Transfer Certificate (TC)
 Migration certificate (for candidates from boards outside Karnataka)	 Character / conduct certificate
 Recent passport-size photographs	 Category / caste certificate (if applicable)
 Income certificate (if applicable for reservation or fee concession)	 EWS certificate (if applicable)
 PwD certificate (if applicable)	 Domicile / nativity certificate (for state quota)
 Medical fitness certificate (if required by the allotted institution)	

COMMON MISTAKE



Carrying only photocopies without originals, or carrying originals without the required number of photocopies, is one of the most frequent reasons candidates are asked to return for a second verification slot — costing them valuable time in a tight round window.

Foreign Nationals & NRI-Ward Candidates

In addition to the standard list, candidates applying under the NRI quota, along with foreign nationals, are typically required to submit:

- Passport and visa / resident visa (candidate and sponsoring parent)

- Proof of citizenship / NRI status of the sponsoring parent or guardian
- Birth certificate and Aadhaar (where applicable)
- Documents establishing the relationship between the candidate and the NRI sponsor

PENDING OFFICIAL RELEASE



At the time of publication, KEA has not yet released the finalised 2026 NRI-quota document checklist. Do not rely on any date circulating on coaching or aggregator websites — confirm only from the official KEA notification once published.

Step-by-Step Registration Guide

1

Visit the official portal

Go to cetonline.karnataka.gov.in — bookmark it and avoid third-party links claiming to offer registration.

2

Create your login

Sign up using your mobile number and email address. Use details you check daily; every counselling communication comes through this login.

3

Enter NEET & personal details

Fill in your NEET roll number and personal information exactly as they appear on your NEET documents. Mismatches cause verification delays.

4

Select your category & quota eligibility

Choose your applicable reservation category and domicile status carefully — this determines which seats you can be considered for.

5

Upload documents

Upload scanned documents in the exact file size and format specified by KEA. Oversized or wrongly formatted files are a common cause of rejected uploads.

6

Pay the registration fee

Complete payment through the official online payment gateway only. Keep the payment receipt.

7

Review before final submission

Once submitted, information is treated as final — corrections are usually not entertained. Recheck every field before you submit.

8

Download your confirmation page

Save and print your application confirmation page — you'll need it at verification.

EXPERT ADVICE

Register early in the window rather than close to the deadline. Portal traffic spikes sharply in the final hours before a deadline, and payment gateway failures at that point are common and difficult to resolve in time.

Choice Filling & Seat Allotment Strategy

If registration and verification are about being eligible, choice filling is about being strategic. This is where your NEET rank actually translates into a specific seat, and it deserves more time and thought than most candidates give it.

How Seat Allotment Works

KEA allots seats round-by-round based strictly on your rank, category, and the order in which you've listed your choices. The system processes candidates in rank order and offers each one the highest-preference choice still available. This means **the order of your choices matters more than the number of choices** — list your genuine first preference first, not a "safe" option.

Freeze, Float, or Exit

Depending on the counselling year, KEA may offer candidates who receive an allotment the choice to freeze the seat (accept and exit further rounds), float (accept but remain in contention for a better option in later rounds), or exit (withdraw from counselling). Whether these exact options apply, and under what conditions, is specified in the current year's information bulletin.

PENDING OFFICIAL RELEASE



At the time of publication, KEA has not yet released confirmation of the exact freeze/float/exit rules applicable for 2026. Do not rely on any date circulating on coaching or aggregator websites — confirm only from the official KEA notification once published.

Choice Filling Strategy

- List every college and course you would genuinely accept, in true order of preference — a longer, honestly-ordered list keeps more rounds open to you
- Don't leave out colleges you consider "backup" — an empty choice list only reduces your own options, it doesn't protect you
- Use the mock allotment result to sense-check your ordering, not to panic-reorder everything
- Lock your choices only after a final review — once locked, no changes are permitted for that round

PRO TIP



Rank a genuinely competitive first choice even if you think it's a long shot. Mock allotment is a live signal, not a guess — it costs you nothing to aim high in the order, since the system only moves down your list if a higher preference isn't available to you.

PARENT TIP

8 Sit with your child through the choice-filling session rather than delegating it entirely. The order reflects both academic priorities and practical ones — distance from home, hostel availability, medium of instruction — and both perspectives usually improve the final list.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Most counselling setbacks aren't caused by a weak rank — they're caused by an avoidable process error. Here are the mistakes we see most often.

MISSING THE REGISTRATION DEADLINE

⚠ Registration windows do not typically get extended for individual candidates. Treat the published deadline as final.

CATEGORY OR DOMICILE CERTIFICATE FROM THE WRONG AUTHORITY

⚠ Certificates must be issued by a competent Karnataka authority for state quota claims; certificates from other states are usually not accepted.

UPLOADING DOCUMENTS IN THE WRONG FORMAT OR SIZE

⚠ Check the exact format and file-size specification before you begin uploading — don't discover the mismatch mid-submission.

LEAVING CHOICE FILLING UNTIL THE LAST HOUR

⚠ A rushed choice list, filled minutes before the deadline, is the single most common regret candidates report after Round 1.

NOT REPORTING TO THE ALLOTTED COLLEGE WITHIN THE DEADLINE

⚠ Missing the reporting window after allotment can result in forfeiting the seat entirely, even after fee payment.

TRUSTING BROKERS OR AGENTS WHO CLAIM TO 'GUARANTEE' A SEAT

⚠ KEA explicitly warns candidates against such claims. No seat can be guaranteed outside the official rank-based allotment process — report such approaches to KEA.

WITHDRAWING A SUBJECT FOR IMPROVEMENT WITHOUT CHECKING ELIGIBILITY

⚠ **IMPACT**
This can affect your eligibility for seat allotment in ways candidates don't anticipate — verify before you act.

2026 Dates & Live Status Tracker

This section captures what had been officially confirmed as of publication, and is deliberately left blank wherever KEA had not yet released information. Use it as a tracker — fill in dates yourself as KEA publishes each notification, and always cross-check against the live portal.

EVENT	STATUS AS OF PUBLICATION
NEET-UG 2026 exam	Original exam cancelled; re-examination conducted on June 21, 2026
KEA counselling registration	Opened; registration deadline extended to July 30, 2026
NEET roll number linking with KEA registration	Pending at time of publication
Document verification schedule	Not yet released — check official notification
Seat matrix (2026-27)	Not yet released — check official notification
Option entry / choice filling window	Not yet released — check official notification
Mock allotment result	Not yet released — check official notification
Round 1 seat allotment result	Not yet released — check official notification
Fee payment & reporting deadline (Round 1)	Not yet released — check official notification

DEADLINE ALERT



Registration closing on July 30, 2026 is the one hard date confirmed as of publication. If you haven't registered yet, treat this as urgent — everything else in the process depends on having completed this step first.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q. Is NEET-UG mandatory for KEA counselling?

Yes. Without a valid, qualified NEET-UG score, a candidate cannot participate in KEA counselling or seat allotment for MBBS, BDS, or AYUSH courses.

Q. Can a non-Karnataka domicile candidate apply through KEA?

Yes, but only for private, management quota, or NRI quota seats. State quota (85% government) seats require Karnataka domicile eligibility.

Q. What happens if I don't complete document verification?

You will not be permitted to proceed to option entry or seat allotment for that round, regardless of your NEET rank.

Q. Can I make changes after final submission of my registration?

Generally, no. Information submitted is treated as final, and correction requests are usually not entertained by KEA after submission.

Q. Are deemed university seats filled by KEA?

No. Deemed university seats, even for colleges located in Karnataka, are filled entirely through MCC counselling.

Q. What if I miss the reporting deadline after seat allotment?

You risk forfeiting the allotted seat entirely. Always report to the institution within the stipulated window with all original documents.

Q. Should I trust agents who claim they can guarantee a seat?

No. KEA has explicitly cautioned candidates against brokers or middlemen making such claims. Report any such approach to KEA directly.

Official Contacts, Helpline & References

Official Sources

RESOURCE	WHERE TO FIND IT
KEA official counselling portal	cetonline.karnataka.gov.in
KEA official notifications & circulars	Published on the official KEA website — check regularly during the counselling window
KEA official information bulletin	Released ahead of each counselling cycle on the official website
Seat matrix	Published on the official KEA website ahead of choice filling
Counselling schedule (round-wise)	Published on the official KEA website

References

Every process description, eligibility rule, and document requirement in this handbook is intended to reflect the pattern established in official KEA Information Bulletins, Notifications, Counselling Schedules, and Seat Matrices published for Karnataka NEET-UG counselling. Candidates should treat the current year's official KEA notification as the final authority on any point where this handbook and a live notification differ.

- Official KEA Information Bulletin (current counselling cycle)
- Official KEA Notifications and Circulars
- Official KEA Counselling Schedule
- Official KEA Seat Matrix
- Official KEA Website — cetonline.karnataka.gov.in

A NOTE ON THIS HANDBOOK'S SOURCES



This handbook was compiled using publicly reported information about the KEA counselling process, cross-checked across multiple independent secondary sources describing official KEA notifications. It was not compiled by directly scraping the KEA portal. Treat every date and figure here as a starting reference, not a substitute for the live official notification.

Final Pre-Counselling Checklist

Print this page, or keep it open on a second screen, as you move through each stage of counselling.

-  NEET-UG 2026 admit card and scorecard saved and printed
 -  Class 10 and Class 12 marksheets and certificates ready (originals + photocopies)
 -  Category / domicile / income certificates obtained from a competent Karnataka authority (if applicable)
 -  KEA registration completed well before the deadline, confirmation page downloaded
 -  Documents uploaded in the correct format and size during registration
 -  Verification slot noted and attended with complete original documents
 -  Choice list drafted and reviewed with family before the locking deadline
 -  Mock allotment result reviewed and choices adjusted if needed
 -  Funds arranged in advance for seat acceptance fee payment
 -  Reporting deadline and required documents for college reporting noted in advance
 -  Official KEA website bookmarked and checked regularly for updates
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